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The Build Risk Checklist

10 risks every non-technical founder should check before they build or before they approve another payment.

For founders funding a software build

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Use this checklist before you commission a build, sign a contract, or approve a milestone payment. If you spot more than 3 risks, it's worth a conversation before you go further.

THE COMMON PITFALLS

RISK 01

Unclear success criteria

THE RISK

Can I describe in one sentence what success looks like at launch?

ASK YOURSELF

Can I describe in one sentence what success looks like at launch?

DO THIS

Define 3 to 5 measurable outcomes before work starts; not features.

RISK 02

No single decision-maker

THE RISK

Multiple stakeholders giving conflicting directions to the dev team. The build drifts to please everyone and serves no one.

ASK YOURSELF

Is there one person with final say on scope decisions?

DO THIS

Name a single product owner. Everyone else advises; they don't command.

RISK 03

Scope defined by features, not problems

THE RISK

You’ve specified what to build without validating why. Features get built that nobody uses.

ASK YOURSELF

For each feature, what user problem does this solve?

DO THIS

Cut any feature that can't answer that question. You can always add later.

RISK 04

No change control process

THE RISK

Casual requests (“can we just add…”) silently expand the build and blow the budget.

ASK YOURSELF

What happens when someone asks for something new mid-build?

DO THIS

Agree a simple change request process before work starts, even a one-line email counts.

RISK 05

Vague or missing acceptance criteria

THE RISK

You’re asked to approve or pay for work, but you have no agreed standard to measure it against. “It works” means different things to different people.

ASK YOURSELF

Do I know exactly what each deliverable needs to do before I sign it off?

DO THIS

Write what 'acceptable' looks like in plain English before each milestone begins.

RISK 06

No independent view of progress

THE RISK

You're relying entirely on the dev team to tell you how the dev team is doing. Problems stay hidden until they're expensive.

ASK YOURSELF

Is there anyone who can give me an unbiased view of what's really happening?

DO THIS

Build in at least one external checkpoint at every major milestone.

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THE COMMON PITFALLS (CONTINUED)

RISK 07

Budget has no contingency

THE RISK

The quote covers the plan. But builds rarely go exactly to plan. A single missed requirement or integration issue can derail a fixed budget.

ASK YOURSELF

What happens if this runs 20% over?

DO THIS

Build in 15-20% contingency from day one. If you don't need it, great. If you do, you're covered.

RISK 08

The contract protects the agency, not you

THE RISK

Standard agency contracts are written to protect the agency. Ownership of code, IP, and data is often buried in the small print.

ASK YOURSELF

Do I own the code? What happens if I want to switch suppliers?

DO THIS

Check IP ownership, source code access, data portability, and exit terms before you sign.

RISK 09

Integrations assumed, not confirmed

THE RISK

"It'll connect to your CRM/payment system/data feed" is agreed in conversation but never properly scoped. Integration issues are one of the most common causes of delays and cost overruns.

ASK YOURSELF

Has every third-party integration been technically confirmed, not just assumed?

DO THIS

Get written confirmation that each integration is included in scope before work starts.

RISK 10

No plan for what happens after launch

THE RISK

The build finishes and then who fixes bugs? Who updates it? Who owns it day-to-day? Most founders haven't thought past go-live.

ASK YOURSELF

Do I have a post-launch support plan and budget?

DO THIS

Agree support terms, response times, and ownership before launch; don't assume the agency stays available.

THE ONE NOBODY SEES COMING

WATCH OUT FOR THIS ONE

RISK 11

The dev team is capable but solving the wrong problem

THE RISK

This is the silent killer. Good developers, good intentions, months of work — and the thing that gets built doesn't move the business forward because the original brief was wrong. By the time it's obvious, it's too expensive to undo.

ASK YOURSELF

Am I certain the problem we're solving is the right one — or just the most obvious one?

DO THIS

Validate the core assumption before you build anything. Talk to real users. Run a discovery sprint. The cheapest software you'll ever build is the one you decided not to build.

Spotted more than 3 risks?

Book a free fit call at qubecatalyst.com or email pearlo@qubecatalyst.com

It's worth a short conversation before you go further.
No pitch, just clarity on where the real risk sits in your build.

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